

UNIVERSITY PROGRAM DOSSIER · THE ADMISSION BOOK

University of Oxford — Psychology, Philosophy and Linguistics (PPL)

Program Dossier · The Admission Book · Fall 2027 Entry · Research date: August 16, 2026

Oxford’s **PPL** degree — Psychology, Philosophy and Linguistics — is the empirical-minds route into this book’s central thesis: study cognition scientifically in one of the world’s great psychology departments, paired branch-for-branch with the philosophy of mind, ethics, and cognitive science taught by the same faculty that houses Oxford’s **Institute for Ethics in AI**. The natural branch here is **Psychology & Philosophy (CV85, a four-year MSci)**. Three facts govern the decision: an applicant may apply to **Oxford or Cambridge, not both, in the same year**; the required **TARA admissions test must be booked by September 28, 2026** — before the **October 15** UCAS deadline; and Oxford offers **no need-based aid to US undergraduates** — the course is financed by family funds and US federal loans. US applicants succeeded at **about 6.5%** university-wide over 2022–24; PPL admits at **14%** with an intake of ~37.

1. The university at a glance

Fact	Detail	Source
Location / type	Oxford, England; collegiate public research university; teaching built on the weekly tutorial	Oxford — personalised learning
Identity line	<i>Dominus illuminatio mea</i> — “The Lord is my light”	Motto
Overall admit rate	~14.1% (2024 cycle: 23,061 applied, 3,245 admitted)	Admissions statistics
US applicant success	~6.5% (2,629 applications, 172 admitted, 2022–24)	Same statistics pages
Course admit rate	PPL: 14% , ~37% interviewed, average intake 37 (3-yr avg 2023–25)	PPL course page
US academic benchmark	AAA standard; Oxford’s published CS-family example: 4 AP 5s, or 3 AP 5s + SAT ≥1470* / ACT ≥32 — confirm PPL’s exact table with the college	CS dept offers (central US table: verify)
Application	UCAS, October 15, 2026, 6pm UK · decisions January 12, 2027	2027-entry guide
Admissions test	TARA (Test of Academic Reasoning for Admissions) — book July 20 – Sep 28, 2026 ; sit Oct 12–16, 2026	Admissions tests
Fees (overseas, 2026/27)	Course fee £54,990/yr + living £12,600–18,900 ; MSci = 4 years (CV85/CQ81), BA = 3 (VQ51)	Course fees · Living costs

2. The big picture — what kind of place this is

Oxford's undergraduate education runs through the **tutorial**: one to three students, one expert, every week, defending prepared work out loud. Admission is built to find people who will thrive in that room, and the university says so with unusual bluntness — “Tutors at Oxford are only interested in your academic ability and potential,” and extracurricular activities count “only in so far as they demonstrate the selection criteria for your course.” This is the inverse of US holistic admissions: no activities résumé, no leadership narrative, no community-impact essay. One subject, argued deeply, is the whole game.

Two structural rules follow. First, applicants choose **one course before applying** and are examined against it — there is no undeclared year. Second, the application runs on the UK calendar: UCAS closes **October 15, 2026 at 6pm UK time**, the TARA is sat in mid-October, shortlisted candidates interview **online in December**, and every decision lands on **January 12, 2027** — before most US regular decisions are even read.

3. The program — Psychology, Philosophy and Linguistics

PPL is Oxford's minds-first joint honours school: applicants choose two of its three branches, and the pairing that fits this book's profile is **Psychology and Philosophy (UCAS code CV85)** — a four-year course leading to an **MSci**, with an extended research component in the final year. (The other combinations: Psychology & Linguistics, CQ81, also a 4-year MSci; Philosophy & Linguistics, VQ51, a 3-year BA.)

- **The psychology strand** is taught by the department behind Oxford's Experimental Psychology degree — perception, **cognition**, behavioural neuroscience, developmental science, social psychology, and individual differences, taught as an experimental science with statistics and methods at the core.
- **The philosophy strand** runs in Oxford's Philosophy Faculty: logic, general philosophy, then options including **ethics, philosophy of mind, philosophy of science, and philosophy of cognitive science** — the conceptual half of the machine-intelligence question.
- **The MSci year** adds an extended research project — the natural vehicle for a human-versus-machine-cognition study, and a genuine research credential going into law school or graduate work.
- **The AI-governance orbit**: the **Institute for Ethics in AI** sits inside the same Philosophy Faculty that teaches PPL's philosophy half, with open lunchtime seminars, the Philosophy, Law & Politics Colloquium, and annual lectures an undergraduate can simply attend.

Alternates within Oxford. *Computer Science & Philosophy* (BA/MCompPhil) is the computational version of the same thesis — algorithms and machine learning alongside the identical philosophy faculty — but it takes the **TMUA** maths test, expects a Further-Maths-heavy profile, and admits at 10% with an intake of 14. *PPE* covers institutions and economics at breadth (TARA, 12%, intake 227) but is lighter on cognition. *Experimental Psychology* (TARA, 12%, intake 49) is the single-subject empirical route if the philosophy pairing loses its appeal.

4. How the pieces fit together

The profile this book is built around treats cognition as the scientific core, computation as the toolkit, and the institutions that govern intelligent systems as the destination. PPL's CV85 branch runs the first two through both lenses at once — empirical psychology *and* philosophy of mind — inside the tutorial system, with the ethics-of-AI conversation happening literally down the hall. The eventual application domain, law, is served the standard UK way: any strong degree feeds a US JD or a UK law conversion afterward. The honest gaps: PPL carries no programming curriculum (the computational identity is maintained

through project work, not coursework), and there is no named law/policy paper inside the course — the governance thread is assembled from ethics papers, the research year, and the Institute’s orbit.

5. An illustrative path (Psychology & Philosophy, MSci)

Year	Psychology	Philosophy	Outside the degree
1	Experimental methods, statistics, core psychology	Logic; general philosophy	Orchestra auditions (week 0); college music award
2	Cognition; behavioural neuroscience	Ethics; philosophy of mind	Institute for Ethics in AI seminars
3	Advanced papers; individual differences	Philosophy of cognitive science	Super-curricular writing; law-school groundwork
4 (MSci)	Extended research project — e.g., human vs. machine judgment	Advanced options	JD applications or UK law conversion

6. Beyond the classroom — the violin at Oxford

Admission ignores performance; life does not. The **Oxford University Orchestra** and **Philharmonia** audition at the start of each term (a 3–4 minute unaccompanied solo plus sight-reading, open to any subject). More than a dozen colleges offer **instrumental awards and exhibitions to students of any degree** — Merton (£300, Grade 8+ standard), New College (£300, recital-based), St John’s (£120/term of lessons + £400), Trinity, LMH, Worcester among them — typically auditioned in the first weeks of Michaelmas term. Choosing a college with a strong music society and instrumental award is the single best lever for a serious violinist here.

7. Access, feasibility, and honest risks

- **One Oxbridge slot.** Oxford’s own 2027-entry guide: “you can’t apply to Oxford and Cambridge in the same year.” This dossier and the Cambridge dossier describe mutually exclusive applications.
- **The test comes first.** TARA booking closes **September 28, 2026 (6pm UK)**; the test is sat **October 12–16**. Registration is the real application deadline.
- **Money.** Overseas course fee £54,990 (2026/27) plus £12,600–18,900 living: roughly **\$85–93k per year**, with **no Oxford need-based aid for US undergraduates** (Crankstart and Oxford Bursaries are home-status only; Reach Oxford excludes US nationals). US federal Direct/PLUS loans are usable. The MSci is four years; the BA branches are three.
- **The odds.** 14% course-wide against ~6.5% US success university-wide, intake of 37. This is a reach on any list — though the least brutal of Oxford’s minds-adjacent courses.
- **Unverified detail.** Oxford’s central US-qualifications table (exact AP/SAT conditions per course band) could not be fetched; the benchmark shown is the CS department’s published example. Confirm PPL’s exact conditions with the chosen college before applying.

8. Applying — logistics for Fall 2027

Step	Date (2027 entry)	Detail
TARA booking	by Sep 28, 2026, 6pm UK	Via UAT-UK / Pearson; window opened July 20
UCAS application	by Oct 15, 2026, 6pm UK	Course choice (CV85 for Psychology & Philosophy), college choice (or open), academic reference; self-report scores — no transcripts at this stage
Personal statement	with UCAS	New 3-question format, 4,000 characters total: why this course; how studies prepared you; what else outside education
TARA sitting	Oct 12–16, 2026	Results Nov 16
Written work	none	PPL requires no written work
Interviews	December 2026	Online via Microsoft Teams; tutorial-style
Decision	January 12, 2027	Via UCAS; conditional offers possible on May 2027 APs

9. Sources

Oxford 2027-entry application guide · admissions-tests page (2027 changes: TARA/TMUA via UAT-UK) · undergraduate admissions statistics · PPL, Experimental Psychology, Computer Science & Philosophy, and PPE course pages · CS department US offer conditions · fees, living-costs, financial-support and US-loans pages · Institute for Ethics in AI · Oxford music pages, college instrumental-awards list, OUO audition page · UCAS personal-statement format pages. All retrieved August 16, 2026; re-verify time-sensitive dates on official pages — 2027/28 fee figures publish after this dossier’s research date.